

Session 21: Defining the Conquest

Key Takeaways

- God is the one who drives out the enemy. He tasks Israel with destroying the places of worship and eliminating any room for other gods in the land.
- The conquest is not ethnic cleansing. Rather, its goal is exclusive worship of Yahweh.

Who Does What and Why

What does YHWH's messenger provide for the Israelites?

- Protection on their journey ([Exod. 23:20](#))
- Guidance to the promised land ([v. 20, 23](#))
- Ongoing instruction ([v. 22](#))
- Leadership in battle ([v. 23](#))

What will YHWH do for the people?

- Oppose Israel's enemies ([v. 22](#))
- Wipe out Israel's enemies ([v. 23](#))
- Throw nations into confusion ([v. 27](#))
- Drive out the nations ([v. 28-30](#))
- Establish Israel's borders ([v. 31](#))
- Give the people into Israel's hands ([v. 31](#))

What are the Israelites supposed to do?

- Do not bow down to or worship their gods ([v. 24](#))
- Demolish the gods and their sacred stones ([v. 24](#))
- Worship YHWH ([v. 25](#))
- Drive out the people from before you ([v. 31](#))
- Make no covenant with them or their gods ([v. 32](#))
- Do not let them live in the land ([v. 33](#))

Why Can't the Canaanites Live in the Land?

Exodus 23:33 NIV

Do not let them live in your land or they will cause you to sin against me, because the worship of their gods will certainly be a snare to you.

The command to drive the Canaanites from the land is not about ethnic cleansing. The concern is exclusive worship of YHWH (cf. [Deut 7:1-6](#); [12:1-4](#)).

Recommended Resource

[*Is God a Moral Monster?: Making Sense of the Old Testament God*](#) by Paul Copan

Reflection Question

According to the text, why must the Canaanites be barred from staying in the land alongside the Israelites?